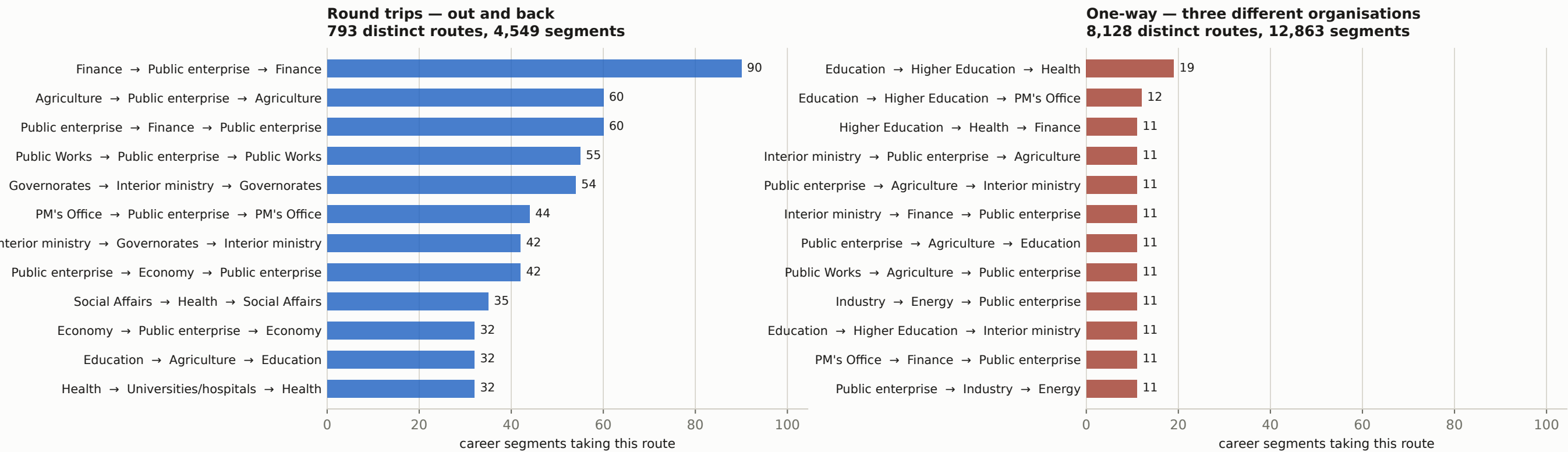


The typical bureaucratic career is a round trip, not a ladder

Every three-step sequence of organisations in the record, with consecutive posts in the same organisation collapsed so that what is counted is the crossing. 26% of them return to the organisation they started from. Drawn from where the middle organisation usually leads, ignoring where the person came from, the rate would be 6% — so a career comes back 4.7 times more often than the transition matrix alone predicts, and the origin is still doing work two moves later. Both panels share an x axis: round trips are few routes travelled often, one-way paths are many routes travelled once.



Source: Journal Officiel de la République Tunisienne, 1957–2026 (6,378 French issues, jort.tn). Author's extraction. A trajectory is the sequence of organisations a person holds posts in, ordered by start date, a person holding several posts on one date placed at the highest, and consecutive posts in the same organisation collapsed to one — an official re-appointed twice inside the finance ministry has not crossed anything. Organisations are named as in the ministry-flow figure. Posts the record will not place are dropped from the sequence before it is collapsed, so a return through an unplaceable body still reads as a return; keeping them instead gives 24% returning against 6% expected, so the result does not rest on that choice. The segments are not independent: one long career contributes several, and a person who shuttles between two ministries contributes the same round trip more than once. Read the panels as a description of the routes available, not as a test.